

sa

ISSUE 8, 2022

Homeschooling

EDUCATION IS AN ADVENTURE

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homeschooling
success

ACTIVE
KIDS ARE
HEALTHY
KIDS

My amazing brain

+PLUS:

Good, sound sleep
for your child

Literary hub

Passed matric?
Where to now?

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SA Homeschooling – Education is an adventure



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online school



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Kezia, Grade 8

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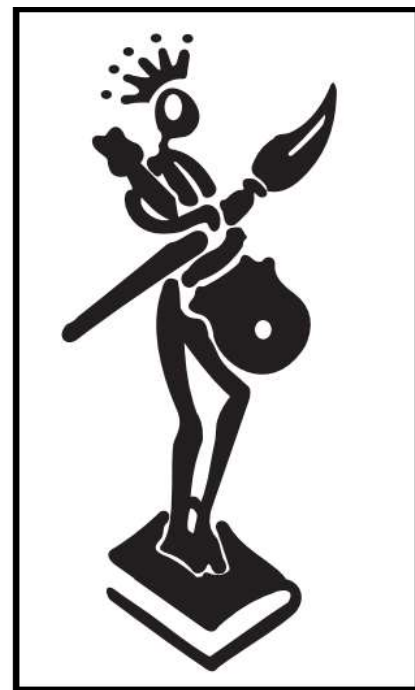
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CHAT TO US!

Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together.

Email our editor, Adri Viviers,
at: adri@isikhova.co.za.



sa Homeschooling
EDUCATION IS AN ADVENTURE



I haven't been this excited about a new endeavour in a very long time. I've read every issue of *SA Homeschooling* since the publication was launched and have written guest articles for it before, so when I was approached to take over the editorial helm, I accepted without a second's hesitation.

However, staring at the blank pagination of your first issue as the

new editor of a publication is pretty daunting. You want to make sure you get it right. You want to address topics that will be of interest and value to the readers. You want to tackle subjects that readers might not find information on elsewhere. You want to speak to the right people in the right fields who can share their expertise. You want to interview families with whom readers can identify.

I thought about each of my three children and their/our educational journey. I thought about the choices we've made as a family regarding their education and why we made them. I thought about their struggles and joys, as well as my own. Suddenly there weren't enough pages to fill – because, while every family is unique, with its own set of challenges, failures, joys and successes – every family is also the same and all parents want the same things for their children: to be happy and thrive.

I hope each page of this issue offers you encouragement and support. May it make you feel part of a wonderful community of homeschooling families and remind you that one of the greatest gifts of homeschooling is seeing your children blossom into the amazing, confident individuals you know they are.

Whatever curriculum you choose, whether you're a homeschooling veteran or just starting out, the top priority is the time you spend with your kids. Not every day will be perfect, but the memories you make together will be priceless.

I feel privileged to walk alongside you on your homeschooling journey and hope that whenever you feel alone or overwhelmed, *SA Homeschooling* will be your go-to source for insights, inspirations and lessons learnt by heart.

Happy reading!

Adri

Education is an adventure

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More families than ever are choosing to homeschool. The Education Department announced last year that the number of pupils enrolling for homeschooling in the country had doubled from 140 000 to 300 000 in just 12 months. Obviously, the pandemic's had a lot to do with it: due to the Covid-19 national lockdown, many parents have now experienced and are more aware of distance learning as an option, and most registered homeschooling and distance education providers in SA have seen a considerable increase in enquiries and registrations in 2020 and 2021. Before the pandemic, there were many misconceptions about what homeschooling actually involved, but people seem to be realising just how doable and beneficial it is.

So why do people choose homeschooling?

One of the main reasons is their dissatisfaction with government education. While many parents would like to send their child to a local private school, fees have increased significantly and have become prohibitive for some. In comparison, education at home is an attractive financial option and gives parents greater control over their children's education.

Internet access has also opened a world of information for parents,

who can create a personalised curriculum for their children, one that truly takes their unique needs and learning styles into account. Homeschooling allows kids to learn at their own pace, with less pressure or comparison

with other students. Equally, they're also able to learn at a faster pace or even skip certain lessons, with no rigid adherence to the progress of an entire class. They can also spend more time on the subjects in which they're truly interested – something which is particularly important when a child's already passionate about pursuing a specific future career.

THIS WAY

Why homeschooling is on the rise in SA

Over the past few years, SA has witnessed a steady increase in the number of families who choose homeschooling and the trend doesn't seem to be slowing down anytime soon. The question is, why is it gaining such traction?



Parents have also cited their children's safety as another main reason for choosing homeschooling. Incidents at schools involving weapons such as knives and guns make distressingly frequent media headlines in SA, as do rapes and other forms of sexual abuse. Non-violent crimes such as theft, vandalism and the use of alcohol or drugs are also concerning.

Another safety issue to which pupils of any age, household income, culture and gender orientations are exposed – in schools of any size, in any location and with any pupil-teacher ratio – is bullying. In a perfect world, the measures schools take to prevent bullying would work. However, the reality is that certain children remain vulnerable to bullying, especially if they're different from their peers in some way.

Some families choose homeschooling because it allows for flexibility. It allows you to adjust your school schedule around your unique home situation or important events during the year. Some

homeschooling families live on farms or in remote areas, where transport is a problem.

Homeschooling also allows room for special needs and emotional freedom. In the conventional classroom, kids are pressurised to keep up, blend in with the rest of the pupils and generally disengage from their individual needs and interests. To a large extent, homeschooling restores emotional and educational freedom.

There's no denying that the homeschooling movement is gaining significant momentum, regardless of the reasons parents choose it. It's no longer regarded as an approach that works only for certain types of families, "difficult" children or a mysterious educational pathway on the margins of society. Homeschooling is now viewed as a viable educational option that has transformative, lifelong benefits well beyond the pandemic.



Why are homeschoolers so smart?

Homeschooling used to be seen as a choice for families with strong religious or cultural beliefs. Nowadays, however, many are beginning to realise that it's a viable educational option that may be a feasible choice for their kids. It can also be a very effective way to improve their grades.

According to research, homeschoolers in the USA on average achieve much higher SAT/ACT scores. This can be attributed to the children learning at their own pace and taking more interest in subjects.

According to a 2018 Businessinsider report, research also indicates that homeschooled children tend to do better on standardised tests, stay the course in university and do better in their academic performance there. In SA, more and more homeschooled students are being admitted to colleges, universities and the workforce.

A study published in the *Canadian Journal of Behavioural Science* last year indicated that homeschooled children also did significantly better than their peers in public school. Public school pupils tested at grade level, while homeschooled kids tested above.

“ It allows you to adjust your school schedule around your unique home situation or important events during the year.”

My amazing brain

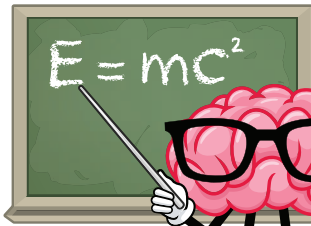
In celebration of Brain Awareness Week, a global campaign to foster public enthusiasm and support for brain science, BrainAbility shares a few fun and interesting facts about our amazing grey matter

From 14-20 March 2022, we celebrate International Brain Awareness Week (BAW). The campaign was founded by the Dana Alliance for Brain Initiatives (DABI) and the European Dana Alliance for the Brain (EDAB) and is co-ordinated by the Dana Foundation. In the 26 years since its founding, it's evolved into a global education initiative which has included the participation of more than 7 300 partners in 120 countries.

Every March, BAW partners across the globe host imaginative activities in their communities that share the wonders of the brain and the impact brain science has on our everyday lives.

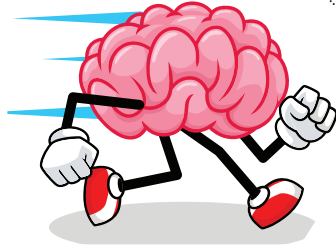
BrainAbility, a registered BAW partner for SA, shares these fascinating facts about our amazing brains:





The biggest part of the brain is the cerebrum, which makes up 85% of its weight. The cerebrum controls our movements, thoughts and memory.

1 Your brain never stops working, even when you're asleep.



2

The human brain is three times bigger than the brain of a chimpanzee (humans' closest primate relative).



3

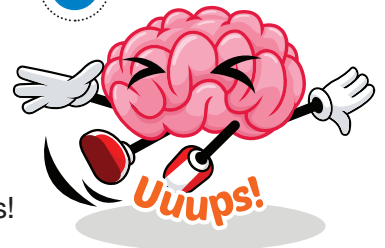


4

Your brain processes about 70 000 thoughts on average per day.

5

Your brain can't feel pain.



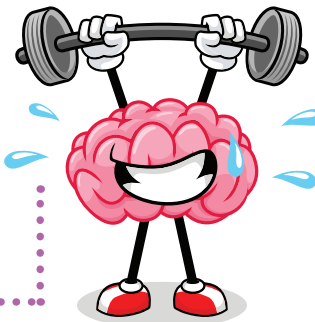
6

Your brain has about 160 934,4km worth of blood vessels – enough to circle earth approximately four times!



8

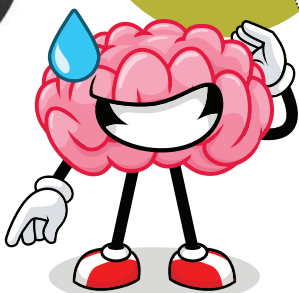
The brain of an adult weighs around 1,5kg and measures about 16cm long, 14cm wide and 10cm deep.



7

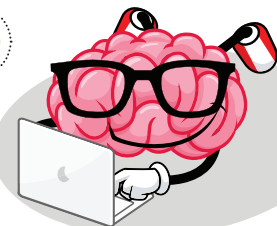


9 The human brain consists of about 75% water.



10

The texture of a brain is very soft, similar to that of a soft mushroom.



11

Your brain has 100 billion neurons – cells known as the grey matter which processes information.



Your brain consumes about 25W of power while you're awake – enough energy to illuminate a lightbulb.

Lack of sleep affects how kids learn

The body uses almost as much energy to sleep as it does when we're awake. Our state of sleep or wakefulness is controlled by the brain's transmitters. These substances switch off the neurons that keep us awake and make us sleepy. During the day, a chemical substance, adenosine, also builds up in our bloodstream which makes us drowsy. Adenosine is broken down again at night when we sleep. Our glucose reserves are also built up during sleep so that we have enough energy for the day to come. And in children, the secretion of growth hormones happens only while they're sleeping.

Experts believe that a primary school child should have at least 10 hours' sleep every night. However, that's easier said than done – especially with children's busy schedules ranging from schoolwork to extracurricular activities, computer and cellphone games, the Internet and TV programmes.

Sleep is absolutely essential for learning. Think of it as your brain's secretary: during the day your brain's usually busy absorbing information, but it's during sleep that the brain analyses this information and stores it in your long-

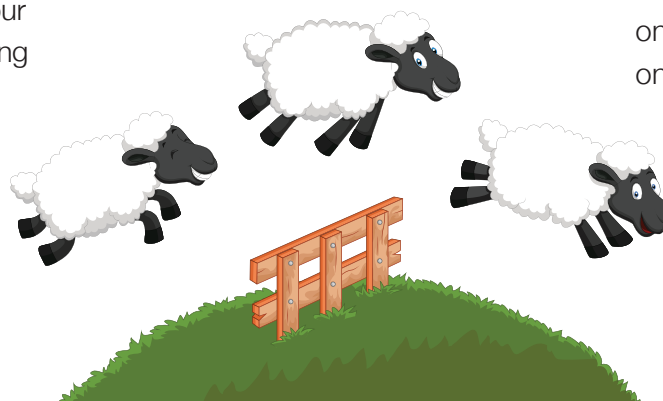


To understand how important sleep is for our survival, it's important to look at what happens when we don't get enough of it. Sleep deprivation has a frighteningly negative effect on the brain, resulting in irritability, turbulent emotions, forgetfulness, an inability to concentrate, lethargy, an impaired memory and poor language control

term memory. Apart from the many negative effects lack of sleep has on the brain, it's also been found that children who don't sleep enough are more prone to overweight and obesity and therefore also insulin-resistance, which can lead to diabetes in later years.

How many hours of sleep should a child get every night? Guidelines released by the American Academy of Sleep Medicine encompass recommendations made by the American Academy of Paediatrics at different times for different ages. The recommendations are based on a review of scientific evidence on sleep duration and health:

12-16 hours (including naps)
for infants aged four to 12
months (younger infants aren't



included because they have a wide range of normal sleep patterns)

11-14 hours (including naps) for children aged one to two years

10-13 hours (including naps) for children aged three to five years

9-12 hours for children aged six to 12 years

Eight to 10 hours for teens aged 13-18 years

There are a number of ways for parents to help their children establish better sleep patterns.

Bedtime should never develop into a battle with tears and tantrums: it should be something your child looks forward to – a time to calm down and feel cherished.

A cool, dark room is recommended and any form of caffeine should be avoided close to bedtime. Make sure your child follows a balanced diet and gets enough exercise during the day. Avoid a heavy meal one or two hours before bedtime.

Cultivate good sleeping habits. It's important that children learn from an early age to fall asleep in their own beds. The bedroom should be associated as far as possible with good feelings, a kiss and hug before bedtime. This should also never be the room which a child associates with punishment.

For younger children, plan a quiet hour or more before bedtime. Try a hot bath, brushing their teeth and perhaps a bedtime story.

Does my child have a sleeping disorder?

There are five common signs that your child may have a sleeping disorder. These are: snoring, difficulty falling asleep, problems with sleep during the night, unusual events like nightmares, night terrors, sleepwalking and daytime sleepiness.

If you notice any of the above in your child, you may want to consult your doctor.

The five most common sleep disorders in children are:

Obstructive sleep apnoea

Obstructive sleep apnoea is a condition in which there are brief pauses in your child's breathing patterns during sleep. Breathing usually stops because there's a blockage – or an obstruction – in the airway.

Parasomnias Parasomnias are episodic behaviours that intrude on sleep and often lead to significant worry for parents. The most common parasomnias in children include sleepwalking, confusion-arousals and sleep terrors.

Behavioural insomnia of childhood Behavioural insomnia is characterised by children having difficulty

falling asleep or maintaining sleep, leading to poor sleep quality and duration.

Delayed sleep phase disorder

Delayed sleep phase disorder (DSPD) is an uncontrollable and common sleeping issue in young adults and teenagers. It causes a shift in the normal sleep patterns by two or more hours (eg falling asleep at 11pm instead of 9pm). Children with DSPD are often referred to as night owls.

Restless leg syndrome

Restless leg syndrome is a sleep disorder in which uncomfortable sensations in the legs create an uncontrollable urge to move them. This usually happens at bedtime, but can occur during other times when the legs are inactive.

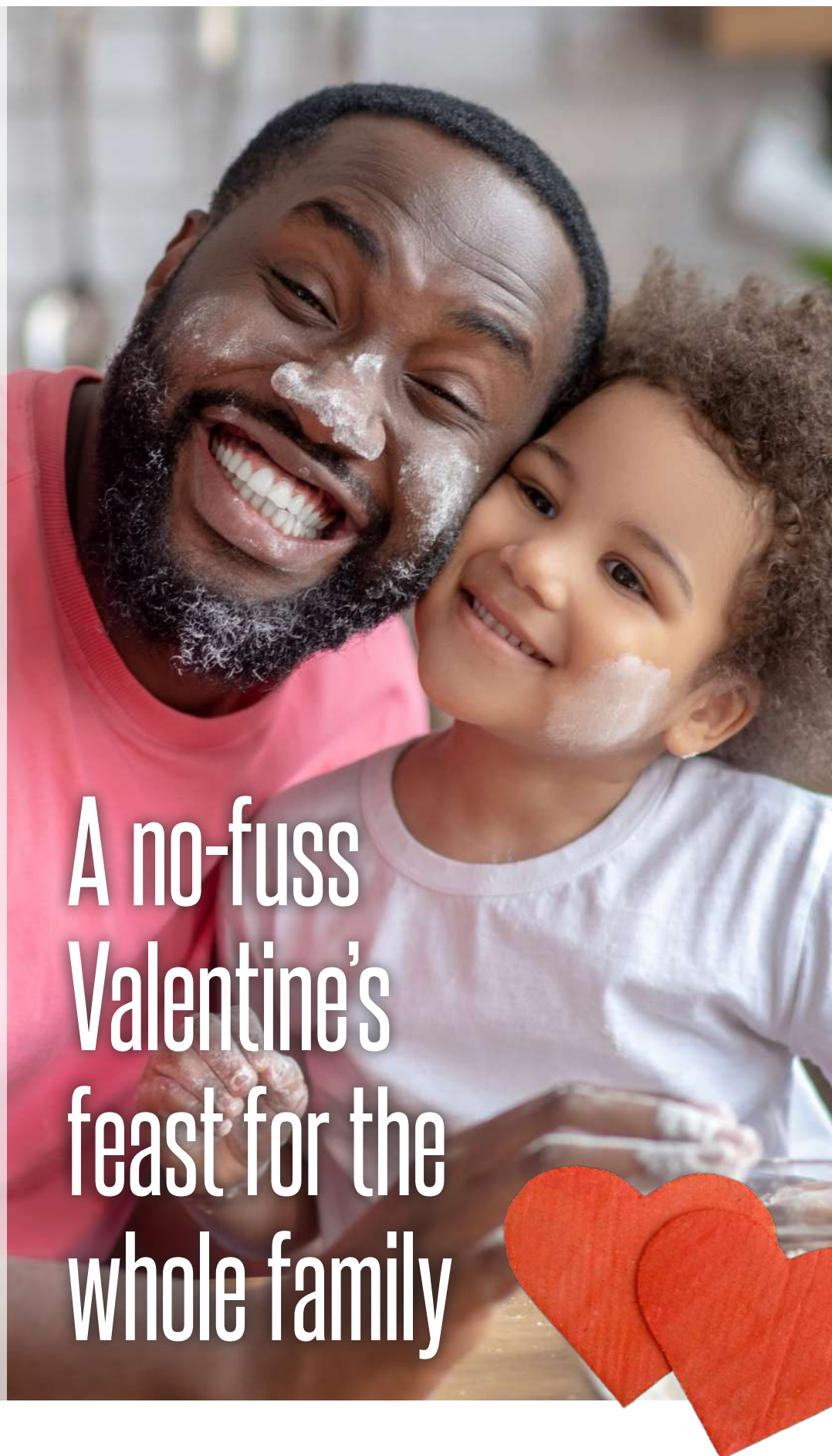


Anri Fourie's two-course meal is a great one for cooks of all ages to pitch in and help with, so gather your family around the stove and make memories that will last a lifetime

I tend to feel a little disillusioned going out for a romantic meal on Valentine's Day. The restaurants are overcrowded, the food's overpriced and if you're leaving the kids at home, finding a babysitter on Valentine's Day is always a challenge. In our house, we like to mark the occasion as a family together and this main course and dessert (that serves six) is a great one for little – and big – helping hands, finishing with child-friendly chocolate pods with dipped strawberries. Delicious!

Bobotie cannelloni with salad skewers

(Set the table using easy, DIY heart-shaped placemats. It only takes minutes to do and doesn't require any sewing. You can make them using pleather, vinyl or leather. Simply fold A3 sheets of paper in half and sketch one half of the heart. Cut and fold open to reveal the full heart shape. Place the cut-out heart shape onto the back of your pleather, vinyl or leather, neatly cut out – and that's it!)



A no-fuss
Valentine's
feast for the
whole family





Anri Fourie, owner of two guesthouses and mom of an eight-year-old daughter and

four-year-old triplets, cooks meals that are quick and easy to make – with multiple little helping hands. In the Fourie household, family time is a great time to cook together. As the former owner of a coffee shop, Anri used to share the kitchen with skilled chefs. Today she shares it with her four busy little offspring who're all eager to pitch in and help.

Preparation time: 30 minutes

Cooking time: 40 minutes

Ingredients:

15ml (1T) cooking oil
2 chopped onions
2 cloves garlic
5ml (1 tsp) ginger powder
5ml (1 tsp) turmeric powder
2,5ml (½ tsp) cumin seeds
30ml (2T) curry powder
500g lean beef mince
2 beef stock cubes (dissolved in 125ml (½ cup) boiling water)
80ml chutney
500ml (2 cups) milk
500g cannelloni tubes (a box is usually 250g)
4 eggs

2,5ml (½ tsp) salt
4 bay leaves
200g mozzarella
Salt and ground black pepper to taste

For the salad skewers:

6 wooden skewers
Half a cucumber, cut into 1cm slices
Half a punnet rosa tomatoes
2 round discs feta cheese, each cut into quarters
1 packet olives

What else do you need?

A deep, medium-sized ovenproof dish
A medium-sized bowl
A medium-sized pot
A small mixing bowl

Method:

- Pre-heat the oven to 190°C.
- Spray an ovenproof dish with cooking spray.

- Heat oil and fry the onions, garlic and ginger.
- Add the turmeric, cumin seeds and curry powder and fry until the onions are lightly browned.
- Add mince and fry until brown.
- Add beef stock and chutney, stir and allow to simmer until most of the liquid has evaporated.
- Season with salt and ground black pepper.
- Fill each cannelloni tube with mince and arrange upright in an ovenproof dish (or horizontally, if preferred).
- Whisk milk, eggs and salt together in a small mixing bowl and pour over the cannelloni tubes.
- Arrange mozzarella cheese and bay leaves on top.
- Bake for 40-45 minutes.

Salad skewers:

Thread the ingredients on the skewers (my kids love doing this!).



No-bake chocolate pods with dipped strawberries

Preparation time: 20 minutes

Refrigeration time: 1 hour

Ingredients:

500ml (2 cups) whipping cream (or double cream)

250g dark chocolate, chopped (I like to use 70% dark Lindt)

30ml (2T) sugar

4 egg yolks

5ml (1 tsp) vanilla essence

½ packet finely crushed tennis biscuits (I use the mint-flavoured ones)

30ml (2T) melted butter



12 whole strawberries (leaves and all)

6 mint leaves

What else will you need?

6 ramekins or any small bowls

1 small saucepan

1 medium-sized mixing bowl

1 microwave-safe bowl

Gladwrap

Wax paper

Method:

- Heat cream until hot (just before it starts boiling) in a saucepan.
- Place 150g of chocolate in a medium-sized mixing bowl and pour the hot cream over it. Allow to stand for 5 minutes.
- Whisk egg yolks thoroughly and combine with chocolate and cream mixture.
- Add vanilla and whisk until smooth
- Mix finely crushed tennis biscuits with melted butter and divide equally into 6 ramekins (press lightly with a spoon).
- Pour chocolate and cream mixture equally into ramekins over the tennis biscuit base.
- Cover each ramekin with Gladwrap and refrigerate for 1 hour, until cool and slightly firm.
- Put remaining chocolate in a microwave-safe bowl and microwave in 20-second intervals, stirring after each time, until melted and smooth.
- Now for the kids' favourite part! Hold the strawberries by the green leaves and slowly dip into the chocolate, covering the berry almost to the top.
- Lift, gently shake the excess chocolate off and place on wax paper (I line a sheet pan with the wax paper).
- Place strawberries in a sheet pan and refrigerate until the chocolate firms (10-15 minutes).
- Place two dipped strawberries and one mint leave on each ramekin. Serve in ramekins.

Kids learn while cooking

Getting kids involved in creating family meals gives them a sense of belonging, security and a huge feeling of accomplishment at the end. It also teaches them valuable skills – while sharing and making memories together.

Cooking encourages children's thinking, problem-solving and creativity. It also gives them the opportunity to use their knowledge and apply it by counting, measuring, following a sequence, following directions and witnessing cause and effect.

When it comes to food prep, never underestimate what a young child can do.



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Support Services: St Stithians Online School

Avanti Gajoo, is the Student Experience Support lead for St Stithians Online School (SSOS). She has a background in counselling and career advisory support which led her towards a student support role in online education. The purpose of her team is to be cheerleaders and advocates for SSOS's students and guardians and to ensure that they feel supported and have the best experience possible on their learning journey.



What student support services are offered at

SOSS? We have a few areas of support that are available to all SSOS families. Firstly, we have my team, mainly the Mentors (based online) and Learning Coaches (based on the campuses) as well as the Administrators who are the first point of call for our students and guardians. We host weekly Homeroom and Learning Compass sessions which are essential touch-points where we connect with students, share important updates, support them in developing important skills and create a space where they can share concerns and questions, as well as connect with their fellow students.

We also have a dedicated Academic Support team member in the Well-being Team. To address any emotional concerns or needs we have a dedicated Student Counsellor and Head of the Well-being Team, Daniella Randall. We

also have a dedicated Academic Support team member in the Well-being team, Sarah Kelly, who is available to ensure we provide academic concessions. Munei Tshiovhe is available to support students with career services and subject selections while Dylan Campbell is our Co-Curricular manager, responsible for virtual clubs and much more.

Our students are also able to book Office Hours (group or individual time with their teachers), or they can email their teachers for support between classes. Further to this, our SSOS families can book time directly with Tessa Venter, our Head of School to connect with her or raise questions or concerns.

Is the quality comparable to on-campus services?

The key difference in terms of support between the online-only and on-campus offerings is that the Learning Coach is available to them in person on a daily basis.

Everything else does take place online so the experience can be very similar. It is still an online school, but with the added benefit of that in-person support as well as the socialisation and connection that is possible when attending the campus with other students.

Does SOSS offer tech support?

Yes, we do! We have a dedicated Technical Support Team that is available via email and phone to support students and guardians in navigating our platforms.

On what platforms is support accessible?

There are a number of ways that our families can reach out for different types of support. The main option that we suggest is using the Student Community or Guardian Community that is set up for our enrolled families, there is a Contact Us tab with a drop-down of support options.

For more information on SSOS, visit www.ststithiansonlineschool.com



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VALENTURE INSTITUTE

Active kids are healthy kids

“Don’t groan about your own exercise – make it a priority and look for chances to be physically active as a family.”

Sean and Antjie Brennan are the owners of Smart Fitness, a personal training facility that works within a child’s and adult’s physical ability to help them become more active. Antjie also does a training programme with foundation-phase pupils at their school to help inspire a love of movement in young children. The husband-and-wife pair tells *SA Homeschooling* why physical activities and exercise are vital for childhood development

“It’s now well recognised that exercise during childhood reduces the risk of developing disease later in life. However, exercise isn’t only about being fit and strong, but is also necessary for brain and emotional development in children,” says Sean. “Let’s face it, when starting out, exercise can feel like punishment to many of us – including children,” says Sean. “Exercising when

you’re fit is fun and something to look forward to, but for kids who’re seldom physically active and therefore tire easily, it’s an unpleasant experience and something they’d prefer to avoid.”

According to the USA’s Centres for Disease Control and Prevention, children and adolescents aged six to 17 should do at least 60 minutes of moderate- to vigorous-intensity physical activity

each day. This should include aerobic activities and those that strengthen bones (like running or jumping) three days each week and activities that build muscles (such as climbing or push-ups) three days each week.

While most young children are naturally physically active and love moving around, closed playgrounds and outdoor facilities during the national lockdowns



due to Covid-19 resulted in many youngsters spending more time inside and replacing monkey bars and swings with tablets and TV. Many parents also feel uncomfortable letting their children freely roam the neighbourhood, as kids did generations ago. But despite these barriers, parents can instil a love of physical activity in their children and help them fit it into their everyday lives.

“With regular, focused and measured physical activities – and plenty of encouragement and praise – the benefits of exercise will soon be experienced,” says Sean. These include:

- the rush of feel-good hormones that promote better moods and help relieve stress and anxiety in children;
- improved self-esteem quickly results as children master once-difficult skills and experience the ability to do increased repetitions (this feedback tends to happen more slowly with academic achievement);
- cognitive development, which occurs during exercise as nerve cells in the brain are triggered to multiply and form new connections, leading to both improved concentration and better memory;
- motor skills are refined and developed by exercise. These



skills are responsible for all the movements we use in everyday life;

- better posture and spine health is established in childhood with correct core exercises and prevents the dreaded teenage slouch that’s normally carried into adulthood if not corrected.

“The obvious benefits of physical activity and exercise such as increased bone mass, cardiovascular fitness, metabolic health, weight management, flexibility and stability also shouldn’t be forgotten,” adds Sean.

“There’s a popular proverb in the fitness world: ‘If you don’t make time for exercise, you’ll have to make time for illness.’ Make sure your children enjoy the privilege and benefits of exercise. Get them excited about moving and being active from a young age and help and encourage them never to stop.”



Tips for keeping kids motivated

- 1 Find activities that **they enjoy doing**. The options are many – from inline skating and bike-riding to tennis and swimming. When kids do something they enjoy, they’ll want to do it, get better at it and do it even more.
- 2 With younger kids, keep the **focus on fun** and expose them to as many games, sports and activities as possible. Family activities such as hiking, guided walks around your city or ball games up the fun factor even more.
- 3 Help kids **find their niche**. When choosing activities, consider a child’s interests, abilities and body type.
- 4 Remember, you as a parent can **make a difference**. Kids look to parents for guidance, support and encouragement. It’s very important to set a good example, so don’t groan about your own exercise – make it a priority and look for chances to be physically active as a family.

Our homeschooling journey – with a

On their blueberry and gooseberry farm in the Soutpansberg in Limpopo, Orion and Adri Theron are thankful for the quality of life homeschooling gives their children. As Adri dotingly watches Marike and SJ run off to the horses, she tells us more about her family's homeschooling journey

Orion and Adri loved what they saw in their three children Hendré (15), Marike (13) and SJ (11) during the 2020 lockdown when their children's school continued with online classes. The children loved being at home and having a more flexible approach to their schoolwork. They laughed a lot, were relaxed and asked if the homeschooling could continue when they realised there might be another possibility of getting through the school system.

How did you choose a curriculum? I found a lot of information on Maroela Media and oolfant.com. Once I had the names of curriculum providers, I Googled them and watched their videos on YouTube. I also had a look at Hellopeter and



“Self-directed learning was our aim and something we wanted our children to accomplish.”

Images courtesy Alicia Thomas from Pix4Paws Photography

touch of farm

phoned them to see how quickly and informatively they could help me.

My husband and I both hold tertiary degrees and it was very important for us to give the same opportunity to our children. As part of our research on choosing a curriculum, my husband phoned some universities to ask about acceptance of homeschoolers. It was a priority for us to choose a curriculum with accreditation and good content.

The children saw Impact's books at a friend and loved being able to write in them, so I knew I should look for a curriculum provider that wasn't only a digital platform.

I wanted a curriculum that would guide us on what to do to stay on track, so that I didn't have to figure it out by myself. It was also important for us to be assessed each term so that it wouldn't be a problem to go back to mainstream schooling, if necessary.

Nukleus ticked all my boxes and also registered all its attendees at Wolkskool, with excellent explanations via videos.

Self-directed learning was our aim and something we wanted our children to accomplish. With Nukleus, this was possible.



Unfortunately, after two terms, we realised that it wasn't working for Hendré (who was in Grade 9). He did his work and worksheets every day, but once he needed to prepare for his exam, it was as if he had to learn everything from scratch. After researching, we decided to try Teneo. It was a good switch for him, as his marks went up. Teneo is an online school where pupils have to attend 80% of the classes in real-time – if they

miss a class, they can go back to the recording. Hendré enjoyed the interaction with other children in his class and the teachers.

Do you have specific school hours (ie, 8am-2pm), followed by family time, playtime, etc, or is your schedule more flexible?

The kids like early mornings on the farm when they can take the horses grazing, tend to the chickens, check out all the birds' nests, and things like that. Normally, though, we start at about 8am. Hendré has to follow the timetable of Teneo, which keeps him busy until 2.30pm. He does have long breaks in between, so Marike and SJ take their breaks at the same time, though they finish much sooner. One of the reasons we wanted to homeschool the kids was so that they'd be free in the afternoons.

What do you consider to be the benefits of homeschooling?

Quality life for the children. Kids can be kids again without falling behind academically – in fact, they actually excel academically, because they take responsibility for the time they spend on their studies. Homeschooling promotes self-discipline, computer skills and self-exploration. It uncaps the limits of a bricks-and-mortar school and has improved our kids' knowledge and communication skills under our supervision. It also stimulates open-mindedness in our children, because they're at home and can

ask our opinions on issues they discover in their studies.

Do you plan to homeschool your children all the way through high school? We've decided to take it year by year and try to stay open-minded about it. Since each of our kids has their own distinctive personality, we'll be guided in our hearts and prayers on the route for them each year.

Does the curriculum that you chose require a lot of supervision and parental support? Nukleus said that its curriculum could be done with very little parental support, but the child does have to have very strong self-discipline. It's very important that their work is marked each day to ensure that they understand it.

With Teneo, the children work much more independently from the parent – I only had to help here and there with technical aspects of the tasks. It even sends parents an e-mail to let them know if their child skipped a class. However, parents can be more involved, if they choose to be.



What are some of the challenges of homeschooling?

All our children miss team sports, which they've always enjoyed. They play tennis, but it isn't their favourite sport.

Although they also miss playing with their friends during breaks, they say they still prefer being at home. When we spend time with other people and their friends, we feel happy about the way they socialise.

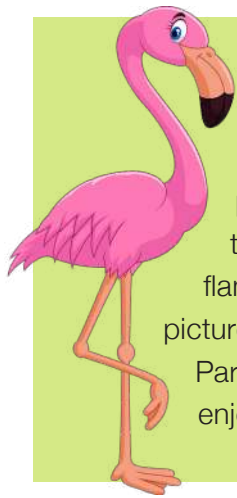
It's definitely a challenge for me being both their mother and their teacher. My time is no longer my own and I have to plan everything

carefully to fit everything into the day. However, knowing the kids are happy and being able to spend more time with them is worth the small sacrifice.

Do your children get the opportunity to socialise with other children? Some of their friends also started homeschooling this year, so we arrange play dates. They also have the chance to socialise at tennis tournaments or at church. Between the three of them, they have a lot of fun and games going on!

Do people ever make negative comments when they find out you're homeschooling? Mostly, their comments are positive. Many of my friends say they'd love to do the same, but as they have to work, they're unable to do so. Some people say: "Oh, that's great, but my kids want to attend university one day." Those people are very poorly informed. After all, self-directed learning is precisely what's needed at university!





Your neighbourhood family park

The [Modderfontein Bird & Sculpture Park](#) is a family picnic park in the heart of Modderfontein, opposite the Flamingo Shopping Centre. Resident flocks of flamingos, ducks, geese and other species provide a picturesque and educational environment. A new Doggy Park section has been added where your pooches can enjoy off-leash fun, obstacle courses and more.

Music lessons at The School of Rock in Cape Town

The [School of Rock](#), an international music school brand, has landed in SA in Cape Town's suburb of Claremont. The school offers various age-specific programmes that focus on building skills. The Rookies course is designed to teach very young aspiring rock stars the basics, Rock 101 teaches kids to master rock music before they embark on performing in live shows, while the Performance Programme is designed for those who are ready to conquer the stage.



Pinboard

Fun local events and outdoor activities in your city and nearby places for the whole family



Red Bus Jo'burg City Tour

The City Sightseeing Johannesburg tour is a hop-on, hop-off excursion which takes you to over 20 of the most interesting attractions in Jo'burg, from Gold Reef City to the James Hall Transport Museum, with a special audio commentary channel for kids. Keep your eye out for specials [here](#) which often run over school holiday periods.

Go quad-biking on the slopes of the Witwatersheng mountain range

Escape the urban jungle and hit the [Segwati quad trails](#) overlooking the Cradle of Humankind. Combine your quad-biking trip with a picnic, braai or maybe even some game-viewing. There's also a paintball range here. Kids must be over 13 years old to go quad-biking. You can experience Segwati on foot as well – it has lovely hiking and walking trails. Segwati also has cottages and a bush camp if you plan on turning your quad-biking trip into a weekend away.



Bicycle and go-kart rentals in Durban

What better way to enjoy Durban's Golden Mile than with a leisurely bike ride along the promenade? [Ocean Ventures](#) at uShaka offers the perfect starting point to take in all of Durban's beachfront splendour. Ocean Ventures offers bikes for the whole family, including a tandem or bicycle with a baby chair.

Mother-tongue homeschooling isn't an option – now what . . .

Many families are now homeschooling for the first time. In a country with 11 official languages, this raises a dilemma when there are few, if any, homeschooling options available in children's mother tongue

The importance of the mother tongue in any learning or development is axiomatic. In their paper *Estimating the Impact of Language of Instruction in South African Primary Schools*, Stephen Taylor and Marisa Coetzee wrote: "Among children in schools of a similar quality and coming from similar home backgrounds, those who were taught in their home language during the first three years of primary school performed better in the English test in grades four, five and six than children who were exposed to English as the language of instruction in grades one, two and three. This finding seems to be in line with the thinking of education specialists, who for many years have promoted the advantages of mother-tongue instruction in the early stages of children's education."

Research further found that children who were taught in their home language performed better not only at school level, but also in tertiary educational institutions.

Mother-tongue instruction involves pupils learning the fundamental concepts of a subject or topic in the language in which they think. Once they understand these concepts, they can apply them when learning a second language. Children understand concepts more easily in a language that's familiar to them, but in a second language, they become "dead" words that are memorised, but not internalised.

There are a multitude of different options when it comes to homeschooling. Thorough research on which curriculum will work best for your child and you as a family will be necessary. After all,

"Even if mother-tongue education isn't an option for your child, you can still ensure that they read in their mother tongue."



every child is an individual with their specific needs and learning styles.

So what can you do if mother-tongue education or homeschooling isn't an option?

Reading definitely remains the most important weapon in your child's arsenal when it comes to academic success. It cultivates understanding – and without understanding, your child will struggle not only at school, but also in their everyday life. As the foundation of language – the primary medium of communication – language is also the basis for emotional development and social awareness. Even more crucially, it's the key to imaginative growth, which is a crucial resource for any human being.

Reading improves a child's general knowledge, vocabulary, writing, spelling and speaking skills, while enabling them to make sense of the world around them. George RR Martin, American creator of the *Game of Thrones* series, once observed: "A reader lives 1 000 lives. A non-reader lives only one."

Even if mother-tongue education isn't an option for your child, you can still ensure that they read in their mother tongue. Make sure that they always have access to mother-tongue books. Join a local library, visit bookstores regularly (second-hand ones are also a good

option) or start a family book club where you discuss books in your mother tongue. Make your mother tongue a part of your daily life.



We also tend to forget how many children learn through osmosis. How many of us have accidentally used an inappropriate word

in front of our children, only to have them repeat it aloud in an even less appropriate place?

Make sure that your child is surrounded by his/her mother-tongue in their daily life; listen to the radio and music and watch TV programmes in their mother tongue. Even if your child goes to school in English, you can still ensure that his home life is in his/her mother-tongue.



One of the most wonderful gifts you can give your child is participation in extracurricular activities which are not only pleasurable, but a valuable learning environment using

their mother tongue. Involve your child in cultural activities such as joining a youth choir, attending arts festivals, and speech and drama lessons, where they can also participate in theatrical productions.

Even if your child isn't schooled in their mother tongue, you can still ensure that they receive the necessary academic guidance in it. Think outside the box when it comes to your child's education. There are several ways to reach the same crucial end result: happiness!

Interesting facts

- The younger a child is when exposed to a second language, the quicker they learn it. Children rapidly acquire fluency in as many as three or four languages if they hear and use them regularly.
- The mother tongue is usually determined by the one in which a person counts or dreams.
- There are 6 000-7 000 living languages in the world today. However, at least 43% of those languages are already endangered – in fact, every two weeks another language dies.
- 21 February is officially recognised by Unesco as International Mother Language Day.

Your Future is at your fingertips

With swiwel.com you can follow your passion and make a career of it

What makes **Swiwel** different?

- World class technology accessible over all devices
- 3D Online expo with additional VR experience
- Over 40 exhibitors and more than 150 qualifications
- Everything from traditional careers to careers that are more aligned with the 4th industrial revolution
- International qualification and placements
- Career guidance at your finger tips
- Pr-recorded workshops with our exhibitors
- Exciting prizes to be won every month



Swiwel
Immersive 3D Expos a division of **3RC**

Monthly prizes to
the value of R1000 to
be won as well as a
GRAND prize of **R10 000**
to be announced in
October

scan me



The Future is NOW

Exploring career options

Swiwel, the world's first 3D Immersive Career Expo, has been launched in Johannesburg. This groundbreaking and engaging, experiential platform is expected to host 50 000 visitors over the next 12-18 months



Well known for hosting live Rocking Future Career Expos at schools nationwide, 3RC is no stranger to innovation. Now it's launched Swiwel, a virtual platform that's open 365/24/7 and is free for all users, both locally and internationally, seeking to study in SA.

What you can expect

Swiwel relies on world-class technology and is available across all devices, allowing entrants to virtually experience exciting education opportunities from wherever they are. Users can put on their own Virtual Reality (VR) goggles and smartphones to "walk" through the platform, with the technology heightening the experience.

Once entrants complete the registration process can:

- Engage with various South African private tertiary institutions and some international placement agencies, peruse 150 qualifications and interact with video views of campuses spread out over two floors.
- Explore over 150 study opportunities, from traditional law, engineering and business options to alternative career paths.
- International opportunities abound, without the heavy financial burden of travel.
- Get career guidance support before they go on a tour to really maximise their time in Swiwel.
- In the auditorium, users gain full access to pre-recorded workshops and presentations from various institutions.
- There are exciting prizes on offer through competitions hosted by the various stands and brands.



'The expo is open 365/25/7 and is free for all users seeking to study in SA.'

3RC is able to map each student entering the platform, strictly adhering to POPI and with parental consent provided for those aged under 18 years. It can then not only gain valuable insights from the data collected, including target audience statistics, but it can generate leads for participating colleges and brands.

Homeschooling entails creating a solid structure at home, despite the constant changes of the curriculum. Eventually, the complexity increases as your child's learning level improves. While this may sound stressful and difficult, there are things you can do to make the experience easier – so take a deep breath and read our top 10 tips of effective, enjoyable homeschooling:

1 Choose your curriculum carefully

Before anything, you need to research your child's home-schooling options. Educate yourself about the different routes you can take for yourself and your child.

You can do this by visiting home-schooling websites and expos, reading books, talking to other families who're homeschooling or subscribing to magazines featuring homeschooling content. Opt for a programme with a proven track record and a money-back guarantee. Talk to a representative from the companies you're considering and weigh up both the immediate and long-term value in the curriculum you're buying.

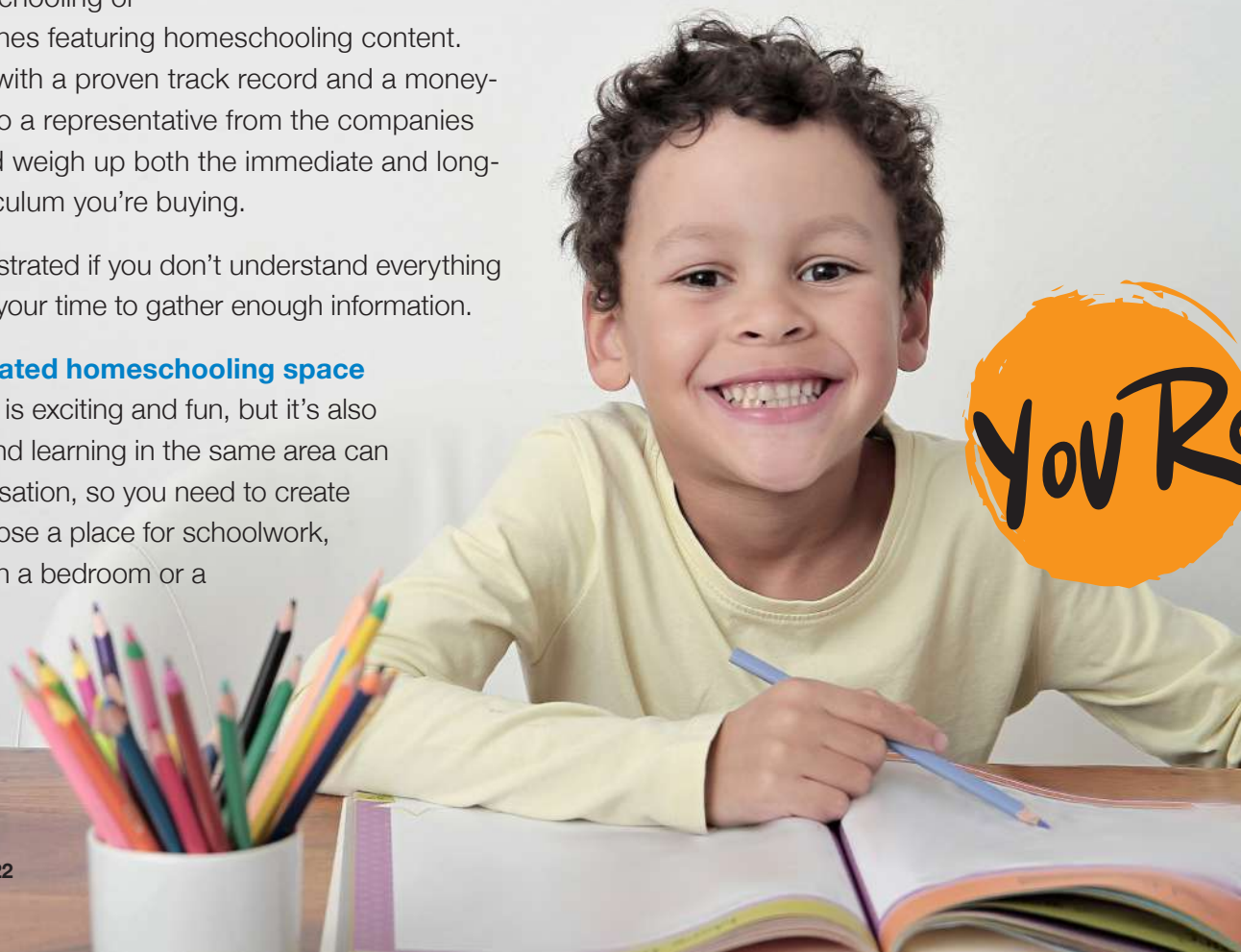
Above all, don't get frustrated if you don't understand everything when you begin. Take your time to gather enough information.

2 Have a designated homeschooling space

Homeschooling is exciting and fun, but it's also messy. Living and learning in the same area can easily lead to disorganisation, so you need to create literal boundaries. Choose a place for schoolwork, whether it's at a desk in a bedroom or a particular corner of the dining table.

10 Tips for homeschooling success

Homeschooling can be one of the most rewarding choices families make. However, many parents feel apprehensive and uncertain at first – with good reason. Indeed, if there were 100 home educators in a room, each of them would likely have a different approach. Here are some certain steps you can take to get the most out of homeschooling



Designating a place exclusively for your child's learning will enable them to focus on their lessons. Get organised even further by purchasing storage cabinets and bookshelves for textbooks and work folders. Baskets are also useful for keeping loose supplies such as stationery, flash drives and CDs in one place.

3 Ditch the distractions

There are many distractions in the day, from a sibling who's playing loudly in another room to a baby demanding attention, a dog barking, e-mails, phone calls, doorbells and text notifications. Don't answer calls or respond to text messages and e-mails until your lessons are done. Instruct siblings to keep noise levels down or play elsewhere during homeschooling hours. The family will soon adjust to this routine.

4 Create a schedule

While homeschooling is a flexible education system, it's still important to follow a schedule to maintain structure and develop a routine for your child. While a schedule makes some people feel hemmed in, it needn't be rigid and helps (especially at first) to be organised. A schedule will also keep you and your child on the right track with your lessons and learning goals.

5 Be flexible

Flexibility is one of the key attractions of



homeschooling – and while a schedule is important, you can adapt it to your child's changing needs. If it's better for you and your child, you can start homeschooling slowly and then add subjects in a natural way that works for both of you. Homeschooling allows you to put the joy back into learning by doing it in a more organic way. Be guided by your child's needs and interests: if it will help them to take walks outside or change

rooms during a lesson, do so. If a friend who's good at explaining a particular topic is available, bring them in for a lesson. If a visit to a museum or the botanical gardens is appropriate, fit it into your schedule. Don't compare your schedule with anyone else's – just work in your own way.

6 Set learning goals

Goals are essential for your child's educational success and will also allow you to customise your child's education and curriculum. When you have a plan and vision set out, you and your child are more likely to overcome challenges and achieve learning outcomes. Set both short- and long-term goals for your child and



use these as your references for your child's learning pace. When both of you know what you want to accomplish, it will be easier to do so.

7 Celebrate
Homeschooling families spend a lot of time together, so they need regular opportunities to blow off steam and relax together. Find big things and little things to celebrate. Did you make it through your first week? Take everyone out for a park playday. Did your child complete their first biology assignment? Grab an ice cream together. Homeschooling holds the potential for thousands of celebrations. Take advantage of them, as they're creating golden memories and reinforcing invaluable bonds.



8 Connect with other homeschooling families
Feeling alone is a terrible burden, so don't let yourself experience it! Deciding to homeschool means you're joining the greater community of homeschooling families worldwide. Connecting with other homeschoolers allows you



to share tips and get to know them online and in your local area. Get together with them, join groups online, attend meet-ups in your neighbourhood and stay connected. You can even arrange joint learning days when a local homeschooler and their own child join you for a shared lesson, so you can observe each other's ways of instructing.

9 Don't buy into the fears
Homeschooled kids are often thought to be less socialised and somewhat isolated, but this isn't necessarily the case at all – in fact, quite the opposite is usually true. Homeschooled kids tend to spend time with a greater variety of age groups and learn more life skills than children stuck in a classroom all day with only peers their own age and adults who're purely authority figures. You can also encourage your child to enjoy social activities with their

friends during weekends, as well as sports or hobbies.

Remember, homeschooling is all about learning and growing together. Focus on the big things this year instead of the little things. Think about the big picture. Remember why you're doing this and keep your eyes on that single goal. You're going to have your difficult moments, but everyone has them.

10 Choose connection over curriculum While you're agonising over which maths curriculum to choose and wondering whether your child's falling behind in reading, remember that the most important part of your job as a homeschooling mom or dad lies in your relationship with your child. Homeschool lessons will end one day, but your relationship with your child will be a lifelong source of joy and blessing.

You *can* do this!

Explore the world through storytelling, music and movement

Situated in Parktown, Johannesburg, the National Children's Theatre – a professional organisation dedicated to empowering, inspiring, entertaining and educating young audiences in a warm, relaxed and theatrical setting – has launched a new programme for children aged one to four years from 1 February.

Children and their moms/caregivers are invited to explore a world of imagination and self-expression through storytelling, music and movement with teacher Tracey Matthews. Bring your blanket and cushions and embark on a magical journey.

During term 1 (1 February-8 March), the programme will (re)discover much-loved tales. Sessions for one- to two-year-olds will take place on Tuesdays from 10-11am, while sessions for two- to four-year-olds will take place from 11am-12pm outside, weather permitting. The cost for six sessions is R600.

These fun, child-centred sessions offer your child a safe and friendly environment in which to build confidence and skills in the per-

“Storytelling is the most powerful way to put ideas into the world today.” –

Robert McKee

forming arts and in life. Music and movement activities offer unique, whole-brain learning experiences which are enriching and rewarding for both children and parents.

The theatre also provides a range of specialised kids' activities and workshops throughout the year. Its holiday programmes are designed to teach children about theatrical productions such as *Peter Pan*,

where they learn to make pirates' hats, sing songs, practise dances, rehearse scenes and more.

The National Children's Theatre is a non-profit organisation focusing on development of art and theatre education for kids. It's existed for more than 25 years and has steadily acquired a reputation as one of Gauteng's premier children's theatres.

To register, contact Cindy on tel: (011) 484-1584 or e-mail: cindy@nctt.org.za.



Homeschoolers' CHOICE

www.sahomeschoolers.org, one of the most comprehensive independent websites on alternative education in South Africa, has compiled a list of books recommended by homeschooling parents to help you on your homeschooling journey



1. *Homeschooling High School*

By Shirley Erwee
(Penguin Random House)

Homeschooling children at high school level strikes fear into most parents. They need information and answers to their questions. Moreover, given the current educational and unemployment problems in South Africa, young people also need clear direction and guidance to help them achieve their goals. This full-length South African-focused homeschooling handbook includes advice on legal matters, identifying appropriate courses, sourcing study material, tips on entrepreneurship, financing tertiary studies and testimonies of successfully homeschooled graduates.

2. *How Children Learn*

By John Holt
(Da Capo Lifelong Books)

Holt uses anecdotal observations that question assumptions about how children acquire knowledge and learning skills. He also looks at the way we learn to talk, read, count and reason, and how we can nurture and encourage these natural abilities in our children.

3. *Homeschooling Curriculum Guide on Home Education in South Africa*

By Willemien Kruger (Kwartz)

Concise and to the point, this is the final issue in a series of seven e-books. It offers information regarding the South African law on home education, the Pestalozzi Trust (a legal defence fund), how

and why homeschooling in SA was established and well-known curriculum providers. In addition, it serves as a guide on school-leaving qualification options in SA and includes details on matric and university admission.

4. *The Three R's*

By Ruth Beechick (Mott Media)

The READING section explains how and when to begin phonics and how to develop comprehension skills. The LANGUAGE section explains how to develop written language skills naturally, in the same way that children learn oral language, while the ARITHMETIC section explains how to teach children mathematical concepts, rather than simply having them memorise theorems and formulae.



A school anthem for online students across SA

The University of Cape Town (UCT) Online High School collaborated with award-winning local artists to release *We Own the Future* – a one-of-a-kind anthem created to inspire, motivate and unite Africa's youth and encourage a sense of community for an online cohort of pupils across the country

In July 2021, UCT and education technology partner Valentre Institute collaborated to launch the UCT Online High School. UCT is the first university on the African continent to achieve such a feat and the public response to date has been nothing short of unbelievable, with over 10 000 pupil applications and the first cohort of 5 000 pupils in 2022.

Continuing this innovation, the UCT Online High School endeavoured to up the ante and create another first – the first-ever school song created by SA's (and Africa's) top award-winning artists. The collaboration, dubbed *We Own the Future* – after a pupil-wide name vote confirmed this as the frontrunner – is a one-of-a-kind anthem created to inspire, motivate

and unite Africa's youth to unleash their potential and encourage a sense of community for an online cohort of pupils across SA and the globe. The launch of the *We Own the Future* school song and music video coincided with 24 January's International Day of Education and is a celebration of aspirational talent for those in need of encouragement and motivation through the power of music.

Collaborating on the school anthem are some of Africa's finest artists, all of whom have won awards on multiple platforms.

Kicking off the collaboration is Cape Town's SAMA-winning live electronic music trio GoodLuck, who're one of SA's most successful global touring exports with multiple



No 1 radio hits. Durban's multi-award-winning pop/R&B vocalist and songwriter Shekhinah adds her soulful voice and lyrics to the collaboration. Adding a rap flavour is YoungstaCPT, who's regarded as one of the most influential South African emcees of this generation. Last but not least is the incomparable, East London-born songstress Msaki, adding her vocals in isiXhosa.

In support of the school anthem release comes a visual story, a [music video](#) that offers a window into the collaboration between the artists and shows the creative process of the school song's journey.

Passed
matrix?
Where
to now?

Of the 2021 matriculants, a lucky few will go on to study at tertiary institutions. However, for the majority, tertiary education isn't an option. Sean Sharp, Executive Head of Sales at EduPower Skills Academy, shares tips matriculants can use to make themselves more competitive in SA's job market

Last month's release of the 2021 Grade 12 results was a cause for celebration, but the reality is that many matriculants don't know what they'll do next. For 12 years or more, school has been their world – but now adulthood and responsibility are looming and they need to make choices that will determine their life's path.

“Entering today’s highly competitive job market is daunting for first-time job-seekers,” says Sean. “The chances that all our matriculants will find a job are slim. They’re in a labour market



where unemployment is at nearly 35%, making the competition for every job fierce. The fact is that two out of every three young people (under 35 years) can't find work and this rises to three out of four for under-25s."

In this environment, says Sean, matriculants entering the job market should be asking what they can do to make themselves more attractive to prospective employers. His advice? "Now more than ever, it's critical that young people enter the job market with a recognised qualification and practical work experience."

His top recommendations for matriculants seeking to acquire the skills that employers require are:

1. Learnerships

A learnership is a work-based learning programme that leads to a qualification registered on the National Qualifications Framework (NQF). Generally courses lasting 12

months, learnerships are a mix of theoretical training combined with practical work experience, delivered by an accredited training provider.

These programmes are sponsored by companies and successful candidates will receive a monthly payment called a stipend which covers expenses such as travel and meals. The amount varies depending on the company, as well as the academic qualification

being completed. If the student is successful, then once the learnership is completed, they could be placed in a permanent role.

2. Bursaries

Bursaries are sponsorships given by companies to qualifying students to further their studies and achieve a qualification. Financially, bursaries generally include payment of academic fees, textbooks, funding for subsistence or accommodation during the period of study, as well as stipends.

Most bursary programmes have strict qualification criteria and some bursaries require that the candidates "work back" the bursary amount after the successful completion of their studies.



3. Job-shadowing/Volunteering

Another way to secure work experience is through volunteering at a company or organisation. While this is usually unpaid, volunteering can be a positive way to learn new skills and network in a business or non-profit environment. Job-shadowing is a learning opportunity to understand the role requirements and tasks of a specific job. A type of



on-the-job training, this form of work experience gives prospective or interested candidates the opportunity to follow and closely observe an employee in a specific role. The result? Newly acquired skills, experience, a traceable reference and – if the candidate works hard and has a great attitude – the possibility of being offered full-time employment.

Sean says that each of these options offers a variety of advantages for matriculants, as it contributes to the development and employability of candidates.

"Ultimately, these initiatives are powerful interventions that can be the start of a long and successful career for the candidates – and enhancing an individual's employability is good for the individual, our nation and our economy," he says.





Congratulations & celebrations!

Team SA Homeschooling and all sponsors of our 2021 Creative Writing Competition would like to congratulate all our Grand Final prizewinners.

We've been so impressed and excited about all the wonderful entries received and about the incredible talent of young, budding South African authors. Well done to everyone who submitted stories. You can all be extremely proud of yourselves.

WHAT YOU'VE WON:

A R500 CNA voucher, a terrific laptop bag, a selection of books, USB memory stick and other surprise goodies.

SAH Creative Writing Competition

ISSUE 5 WINNERS



Game Reserve Adventure

By Shanon Strauss, age 10

Click [here](#) to read the story



A Punctuation-Free World

By Sophia de Lange, age 13

Click [here](#) to read the story



Realm Seer

By Jordan Mikha Prince, age 15

Click [here](#) to read the story

ISSUE 6 WINNERS



A Night of Horrors

By Kimaya Valabh, age 10

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The Samuels Gang and the Lost Tiger: Part 1

By Kevahn Samuels, age 11

Click [here](#) to read the story



Change Begins at the End of Your Comfort Zone

By Zaibaa Rawat, age 13

Click [here](#) to read the story

ISSUE 7 WINNERS



My Perfect Holiday

By Mariam Mahomed, age 8

Click [here](#) to read the story



Mama Seeks

By Anae Labuschagne, age 11

Click [here](#) to read the story



The Adversities of Self-Discovery

By Nompumelelo Xaba, age 15

Click [here](#) to read the story

Grand prize-winner (8-10 year category)

Game reserve adventure

By Shanon Strauss, age 10

Levi, my family and I were in the Kruger. It was a hot, beautiful night. The stars scattered the night sky like a floor when a baby is giving glitter and left alone.

We were finishing our food when we got some very, very, very, very, (you get the point) bad news. There was a poacher in town. The message came on Dad's WhatsApp: 'Help if you can.'

My brother Zac screamed, 'WHYY YYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYY YYYYYY?'

'Zac, stop!' said Dad.

'How can we help?' asked Levi and I in unison.

'Jinx,' Levi and I said in unison. We said 'jinx' again. This went on for quite a while. Twenty-three minutes later dad shouted, 'Enough you two. This is serious.'

'Let's discuss this tomorrow,' said Mom.

'I have an idea,' I said.

'What's the idea?' Levi asked.

'We make a fake rhino. Then we put it sleeping somewhere. We will put a trap all around the rhino so when the poacher shoots it and comes to get the horn, he will fall in the trap,'

'How will we do this?' asked mom.

Dad said, 'In the whatsapp it said the poacher is a wanted criminal. I'm sure the police will help us make a fake rhino.'

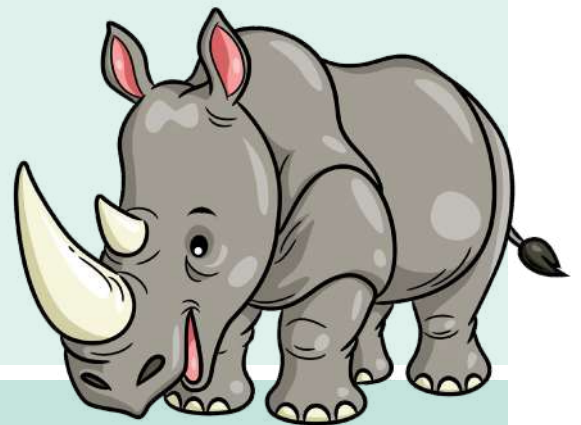
Three days later we had completed the replica rhino with the help of the police engineers. One of them suggested that we should make the inside have water with red food colouring, so when the poacher shoots the rhino the red water will come out and he will think it's blood. The trap was set. It was now a waiting game.

We hid a camera in a tree nearby. I felt more nervous than an apple about to get eaten. My heart was racing faster than a Lamborghini Veneno. Just as we were starting to get bored watching the camera, we heard footsteps.

Suddenly I heard a loud BANG.

Since I am a gun expert, I knew the poacher had a P90 (a gun favoured by poachers). We then heard a loud CLANK! The sound of his gun breaking into pieces as he fell into the hole we had dug in front of the rhino. My plan had worked! I was ecstatic. Happier than a child in a toy shop with an unlimited budget.

The police were watching with us and congratulated me on my successful plan. They went to the hole to arrest the man. Later that day, we were invited to the town hall to be rewarded seven million rand for catching a wanted criminal. The money was great, but what made me the happiest was that the poacher would be behind bars and I had saved the rhinos.



What the judges said

Shanon achieved the almost impossible here, by writing a rollicking adventure in so few words. The pace was wild (see what we did there?) and the original similes were clever and to the point.

Grand prize-winner (11-13 year category)

Change begins at the End of Your Comfort Zone *By Zaibaa Rawat, age 13*

Starting over... It's something I used to find hard to do. You know, saying goodbye to everything and everyone you've grown to love.

I didn't know what to say when my mother said we were moving, I didn't know how to react when she told me that she and Dad were separating, and I definitely didn't know what to do when I found out

that my best friends had betrayed me. I hadn't realised how much could happen until today.

I was always told I showed too many emotions. Too much sadness. Too much anger. Too much negativity. The only thing I heard was: 'Stop being so dramatic!' and 'You're too sensitive.' But that day, after everything happened, I smiled. Smiled at how ironic everything was. I'd always thought my best

friends would be there for me. I'd always thought my parents were happy.

I remember something my grandma once said: 'All things bad for you will, one way or another, come to an end.' I finally understood what she meant.

The next day, packing my things wasn't hard at all. Learning to accept and move on is something a lot of people struggle to do, but at that moment, I felt relieved. I'm not sure why, but I did.

This unknown feeling, that I didn't know I needed, settled over me. Making me laugh at how right my grandma was.

'Once those bad things you didn't know about leave, you'll have this – how do I put it? – relieved feeling. When you first see the bad things leave, it will hurt. I'm not going to lie. But once it's gone, I'm telling you, sweetie, you'll be lighter. Happier.' She really was a wise woman.

And that's when I realised change doesn't feel that hard.



What the judges said

Zaibaa's story really grabbed our hearts, taking us back to when we were teens suffering through the changes and challenges that life threw at us. Zaibaa writes with great sensitivity and depth.



Grand prize-winner (14-17 year category)

The adversities of self-discovery

By Nompumelelo Xaba, age 15

It is incredibly difficult to think about the journey to self-discovery and not think about the discomfort, the desire to always improve and, above all else, the lingering insecurities as you grow older. Growing up, we are given this narrow view of what fulfilment, success and happiness look like, so that our minds are programmed to think in a certain way. We find ourselves in positions where we even question our own potential and abilities to be anything but what we have been programmed to deem as acceptable by both society and our parents.

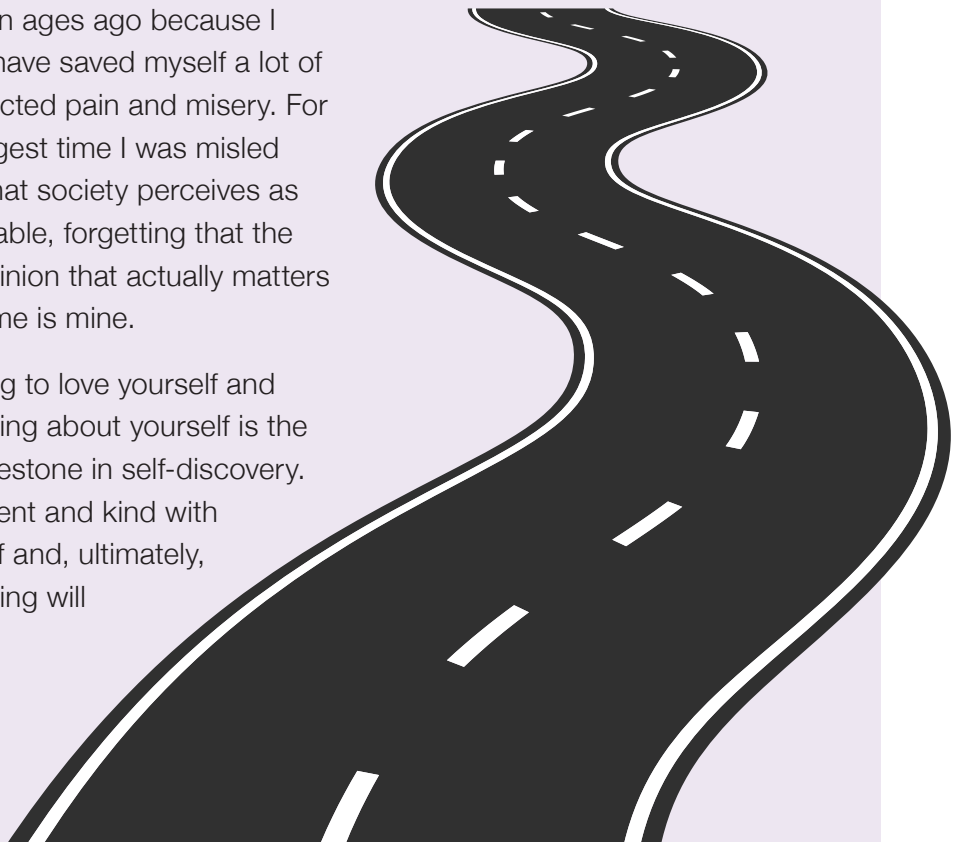
The parameters by which success is measured are different from person to person, but we can all agree that it is commonly measured by material wealth such as lavish cars, a luxurious home, a spouse, perhaps two or more kids and, ultimately, a good job. Shying away from the fact that it is tremendously pressurising would be an injustice

to ourselves because we spend so much time trying to be anything but ourselves that we end up losing our authenticity, which is the most beautiful thing we can embody.

It took me the past few months of my life to realise how much I could do if I looked just a few inches away from what people considered 'good enough'. That was when my self-discovery journey started, a journey I wish I'd taken ages ago because I would have saved myself a lot of self-inflicted pain and misery. For the longest time I was misled with what society perceives as acceptable, forgetting that the only opinion that actually matters about me is mine.

Learning to love yourself and everything about yourself is the first milestone in self-discovery. Be patient and kind with yourself and, ultimately, everything will

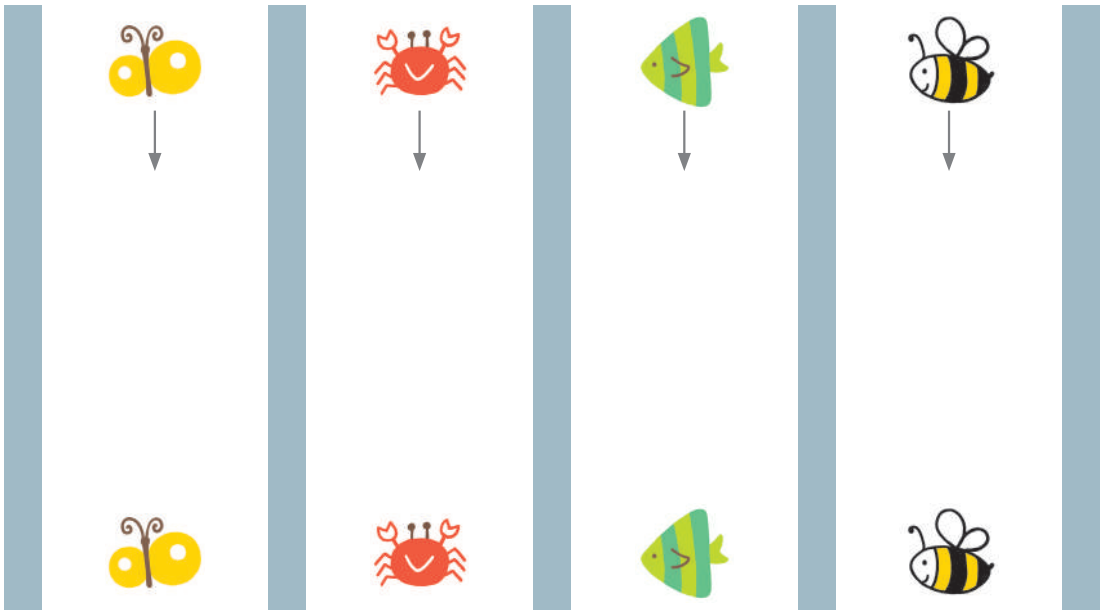
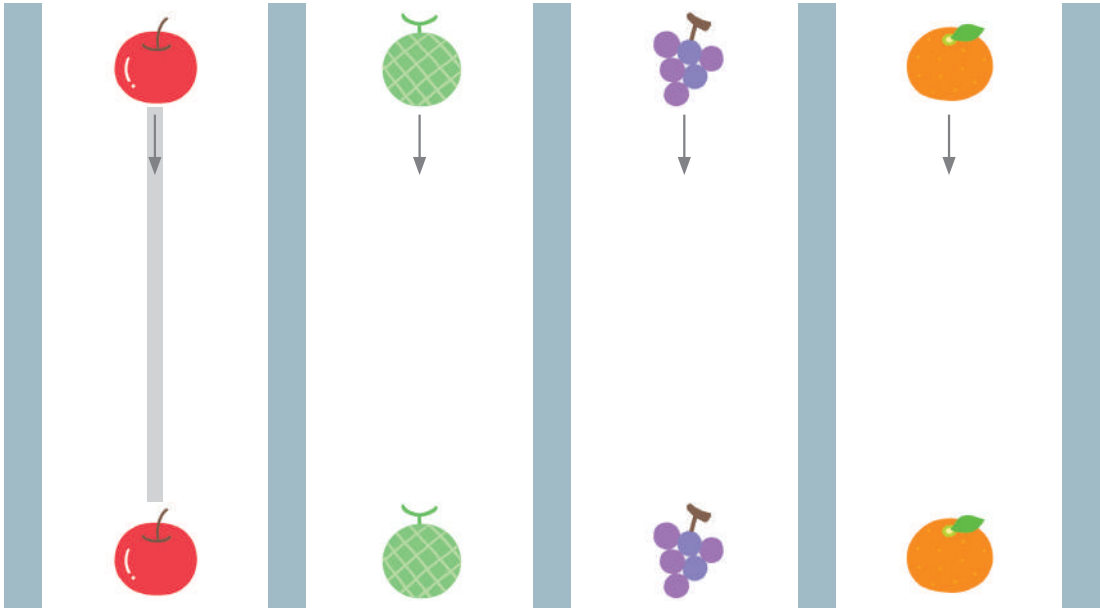
come full circle. A big part of finding yourself is accepting the past as you work towards the future. This will not happen overnight, so the journey will be long and challenging from time to time, but with every challenge comes a lesson and that is how you learn more about yourself. The adversities in self-discovery are countless, but definitely worth every little step.



What the judges said

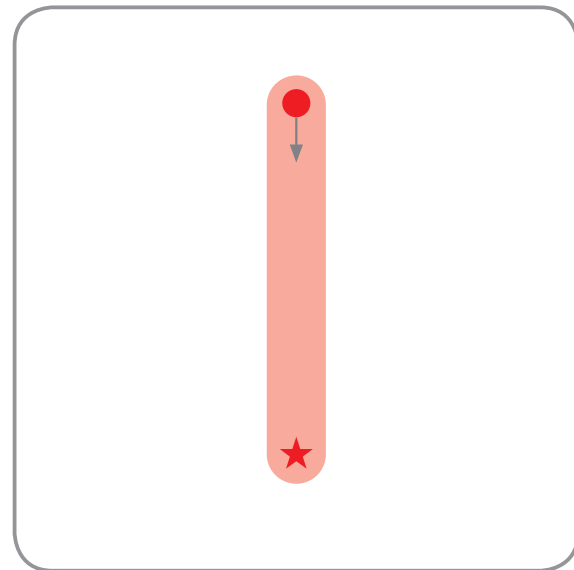
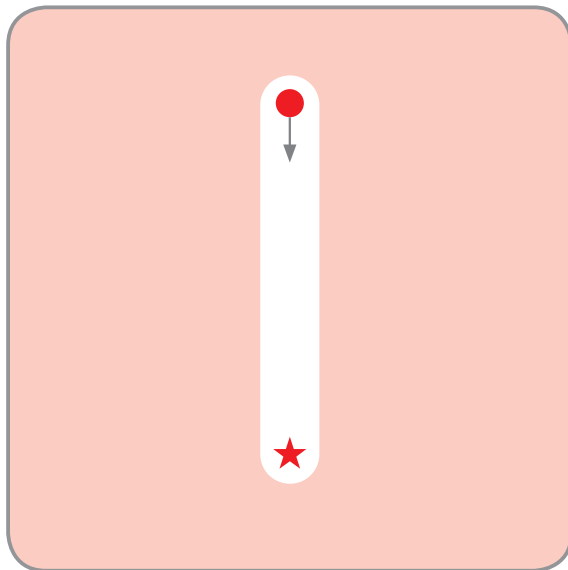
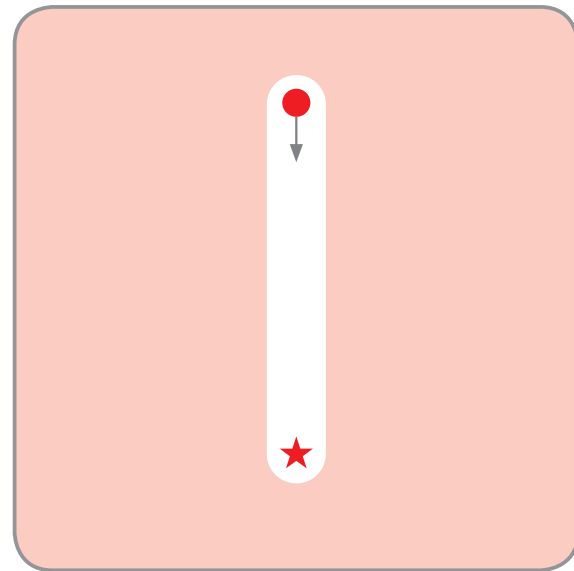
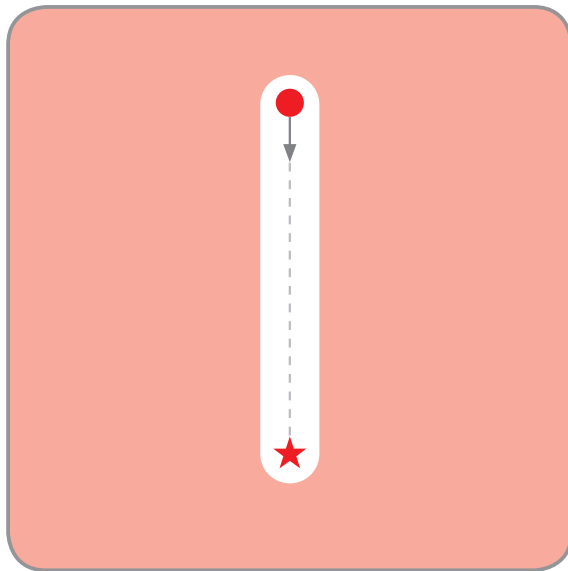
Nompumelelo shows great wisdom and we believe this message should be shared far and wide.

■ Draw a line from one picture to the matching picture.



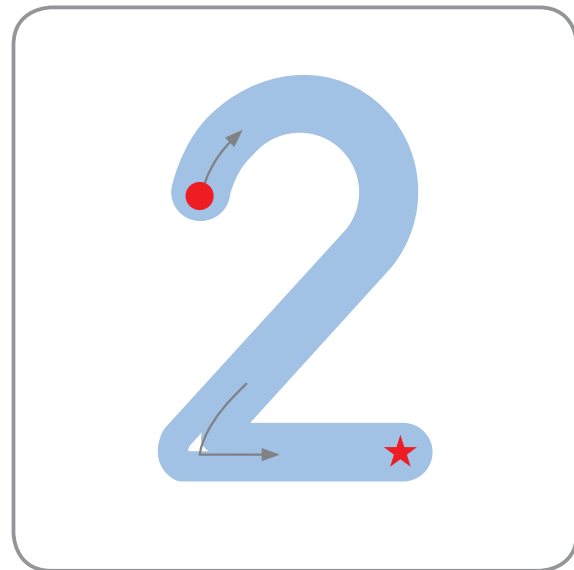
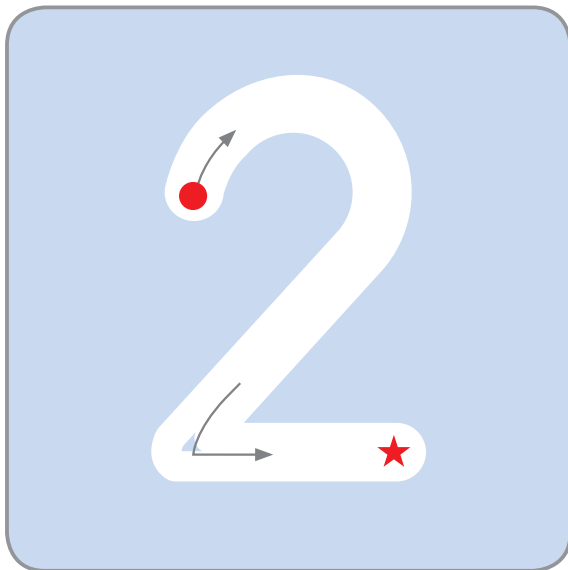
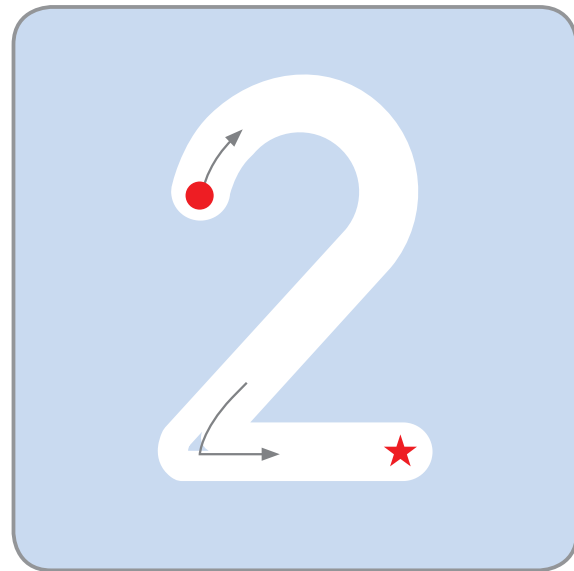
- Write the number 1 and say it aloud.

one



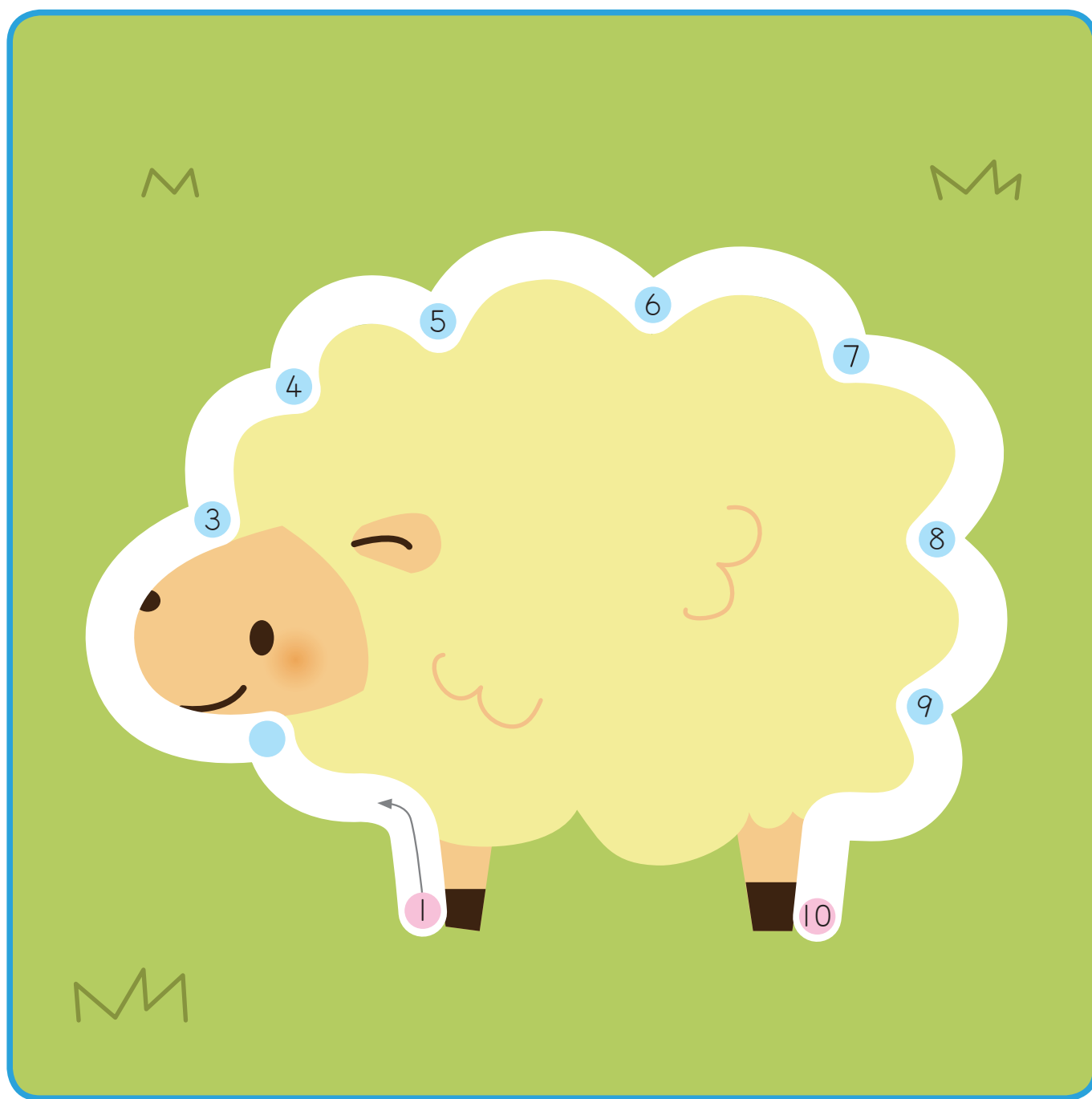
- Write the number 2 and say it aloud.

two



Sheep

- Draw a line from 1 to 10 in order while saying each number.



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